

Sand dunes, medieval forts and a sky thick with stars

At a Glance

State	Rajasthan
Best Time	October – February
Airport	Jaisalmer Airport (flights from Delhi & Jaipur)
UNESCO	Hill Forts of Rajasthan WHS (2013)
Elevation	225 m above sea level
Famous For	Living sandstone fort, Sam Sand Dunes, camel safaris, ornate havelis

Overview

Rising dramatically from the heart of the Thar Desert, Jaisalmer is one of India's most strikingly situated cities. Founded in 1156 CE by Rajput ruler Rawal Jaisal, the city is crowned by the immense Jaisalmer Fort — a UNESCO-listed living fort still inhabited by approximately 3,000 people within its 12th-century walls.

Known as the 'Golden City', almost every structure is built from golden-yellow Jurassic sandstone (Dolomite), which glows a warm honey-amber at sunrise and sunset. Jaisalmer was once a vital trading post on the ancient Silk Route, and its elaborate merchant havelis adorned with intricate jali-screen carvings testify to that extraordinary prosperity. Today the city is a gateway to the endless Thar Desert and one of India's most romantic destinations.

Top Attractions

Jaisalmer Fort — Sonar Quila

A UNESCO-listed 'living fort' with 99 bastions, home to palaces, Jain temples, ornate havelis, restaurants and guesthouses within medieval golden walls. The only fort in India where roughly a quarter of the city's population still resides inside the ramparts.



■ *Jaisalmer Fort — Sonar Quila*

Sam Sand Dunes & Camel Safari

About 42 km from the city, Sam offers the complete Thar Desert immersion: camel safaris at golden hour, traditional Rajasthani folk music and dance performances, and sleeping under the most spectacular star-filled sky in India.



■ *Sam Sand Dunes & Camel Safari*

Patwon Ki Haveli

The largest and grandest haveli in Jaisalmer, comprising five connected mansions built in the early 19th century by a wealthy brocade merchant family. Its facades are covered in extraordinarily detailed golden sandstone filigree carvings.



■ *Patwon Ki Haveli*

Gadisar Lake

A 14th-century rainwater harvest lake surrounded by golden temples, ghats and shrines. Perfect for a tranquil sunrise boat ride with migratory ducks and coots in winter, and one of Jaisalmer's most peaceful spots away from the fort crowds.



■ *Gadisar Lake*

Local Cuisine & Flavours

- Dal Baati Churma — Rajasthan's soul dish: baked wheat balls, five-lentil dal & sweet crumble
- Ker Sangri — traditional desert pickle-curry made from wild berries & desert beans
- Laal Maas — fiery red mutton curry cooked with Mathania chillies, a Rajput classic
- Ghewar — a latticed disc sweet soaked in sugar syrup and topped with rabri cream
- Bajre ki Roti with Lahsun Chutney — millet flatbread with pungent garlic chutney

How to Get There

- By Air: Jaisalmer Airport with daily flights from Delhi and Jaipur.
- By Train: Jaisalmer–Delhi Express (overnight train); also connections from Jodhpur.
- By Road: ~300 km from Jodhpur (~5 hrs); buses and cabs available from major Rajasthan cities.
- By Road from Jaipur: ~575 km (~10 hrs drive through the magnificent Thar landscape).

Insider Travel Tips

- The Desert Festival (February) features turban-tying, camel polo & folk music — don't miss it.
- Book an overnight dune camp — the Thar night sky with zero light pollution is extraordinary.
- Wear covered clothing for camel safaris — sun and sand are intense even in winter.
- Bargain confidently in the fort bazaar for embroidered fabrics, silver jewellery and carpets.
- Visit Jain temples inside the fort early morning (before 11 AM) for a peaceful darshan.

*We hope this guide inspires your journey to **Jaisalmer — Rajasthan**. Travel responsibly, respect local traditions, and leave only footprints.*